

The Art of Client Service

Managing Client Expectations

Why Expectations Matter More Than Performance

- Mismatched expectations = perceived failure (even with good outcomes)
- Clear expectations = trust, patience, and partnership
- Surprises erode confidence faster than bad news

Clients don't judge us only by results. They judge us by whether reality matches what they *expected*.

Expectation Management Is a Leadership Skill

-  Clients don't want vendors, they want *advisors*
-  Advisors help clients understand trade-offs and constraints
-  Clients buy outcomes, not activities
-  Your job is to guide them through reality—not validate assumptions



The **3 Types of Expectations** You Must Manage

1. Outcome Expectations

What success actually looks like

2. Process Expectations

How work gets done (timelines, inputs, reviews)

3. Relationship Expectations

How communication, ownership, and escalation work

The #1 Expectation Failure: Implicit Assumptions

Common Traps:

- “They know how this works”
- “We talked about this once”
- “It’s implied”



If it's not documented, it's not agreed. Verbal alignment $\neq$ shared understanding.

Replace Assumptions With Explicit Agreements

Best Practice

Turn assumptions into:

- Written plans
- Defined success criteria
- Agreed timelines and responsibilities

Language to Model

- “Let’s align on what success looks like”
- “Here’s what we can control vs. what we can’t”
- “Here’s what happens if X slips”

The Trusted Advisor Mindset: Saying No Without Losing Trust

Saying yes to everything is not service. *It's abdication of responsibility.*

Good advisors protect clients from bad decisions. Even when those decisions are requested.

How to Reframe “No” as Leadership

Structure

1. Acknowledge the goal
2. Explain the constraint
3. Offer a viable alternative

Example

“1. I understand why you want this outcome. 2. Given the timeline and data we have, this approach won’t get us there. 3. Here’s what *will* move us forward.”

Expectations Are Ongoing, Not One-Time

Alignment decays. Context fades. Teams change.

Best Practice:

- Re-anchor expectations regularly
- Especially at:
 - ◆ Monthly reviews
 - ◆ Scope changes
 - ◆ Performance dips

When Expectations Must Be Set - A Simple Matrix

Mandatory Expectation Setting Moments

- ◆ Onboarding / kickoff
- ◆ Strategy changes
- ◆ Budget changes
- ◆ Performance inflection points (up or down)
- ◆ Before QBRs (not during)
- ◆ After missed timelines or dependencies

Managing Expectations During Change

Reality

- Strategy shifts
- Markets change
- Priorities evolve
- **Shit happens.**

Re-set expectations *at the moment of change*, not after impact.

The Power of Narrative Updates

Bad Update:

-  “We’re behind.”

Good Update:

-  What changed
-  Why it matters
-  What’s being done
-  What to expect next

Warning Signs Expectations Are Slipping

- Vague dissatisfaction
- “Just checking in” emails
- Sudden urgency
- Shifting success definitions



What Great CS Does:

1. Makes the goal measurable
2. Names the constraints early
3. Documents the plan + owners
4. Flags risks before they hurt
5. Resets expectations fast when reality changes

Expectation Management is Part of Performance Reviews

AM performance is judged on:

- ◆ Clarity of expectations set
- ◆ Quality of documentation
- ◆ Proactive risk flagging
- ◆ Client surprise rate (zero is the goal)
- ◆ Ability to say no with context

Final Takeaway:

The Real Job

Your job isn't [just] to manage accounts.

It's to manage expectations so results can be evaluated fairly.